

Getting ideas from users

A potential source of innovation can be frustration: the frustration experienced by users who want something additional or different from the products and services they use. This can be channeled to create ideas and prototypes for innovations. For example, Linux is not a product developed by a large corporation, but the result of collaboration among a community of users who wanted software that better suited their needs, and they continue improving and updating it. Going to an older example: the pickup truck was not invented in Detroit by the large American car companies, but emerged on farms where farmers had bought the early trucks, stripped out the seats, taken off the roof, and improvised a truck more suited to their farm needs. Work with “lead users” to capture their insights and prototypes. During process innovation inside the organization, use suggestion programs to capture employee ideas. Use web communities—or “crowd sourcing”—to help create ideas for innovation or improve on what is already there.

TIP

REVIEW RELEVANCE

As your project progresses, keep monitoring not only expenditure and performance, but also its continuing relevance to end users. Otherwise you may find yourself with a perfectly executed innovation that your customers no longer want.

CASE STUDY

Getting ideas from outside

Procter and Gamble (P&G) used to spend around \$3 billion each year on technology research, and employed more than 7,000 people to carry it out. However, it has now committed to sourcing half of its innovations from outside the company. In doing so, it has had to develop completely new ways of working, sharing its unused ideas with a wider world, and picking up on other people's

ideas in the most unlikely of places. For example, the idea of Pringles potato chips having messages printed on them was made a reality not by P&G research scientists but by connecting with a small bakery in Bologna, Italy, that had developed a special edible ink and a spraying process for the ink. The connection was made through one of the increasing number of Internet knowledge broker sites—a kind of eBay for innovation.